

done, I assumed that the die was cast and that nothing further would be—or could be—done to influence the outcome.

Then, only a few days before the scheduled stockholders'

meeting, one of my aides burst into my office. His face was livid with anger and he clutched a piece of paper in his hand.

"Read this!" he exclaimed, thrusting the paper at me. I took it and found that it was a letter—a *second* letter—

which the opposition had sent out to the stockholders only a day or two earlier. And what a letter it was!

The gist of the no-holds-barred missive was a virulent personal attack on me and a highly objectionable—and entirely baseless—implication that my motives for seeking control of the company were, at best, dubious. I called my associates and held a hasty council of war. What could be done at that late stage of the game? Not much, some of my associates declared dispiritedly. There wasn't enough time.

"I'm afraid this licks us, Paul," one man said, shaking his head in resignation. "Nothing in this letter is true—but it's going to have a tremendous impact on the stockholders.

Not having any way of checking up on the charges that have been made, they'll play it safe and give their proxies to the other side."

"You really think we're licked?" I asked, glancing around at the men in the room with me. Some heads nodded assent. The faces of some other men showed that they weren't entirely convinced that all was lost. A few of my

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associates indicated that they refused to accept defeat that easily.

"Nuts!" one of them snorted. "We still have a chance!"

"I think so, too," I said. "Now, let's get to work."